

One of the improvements that Netscape 3 browser boasted off was “mouseover” which means showing one image when a link is highlighted and a different one when it is not. At the time, Netscape 3 was considered the benchmark for all other browsers and if you wanted to be in the browser market, you would be better off supporting all features that Netscape 3 supported.

June 1997 saw the release of Netscape 4 while IE 4 was released in October 1994 and things started to go wrong for Netscape. Both browsers used DHTML (the changing of CSS by means of JavaScript), but had their own implementations and did not pay attention to how the other browser worked. Suddenly Web sites that used DHTML (or CSS with JavaScript) could be displayed in Netscape and not in IE and vice versa. But Microsoft acting mostly on hindsight went back to the drawing board and wrote the code right from the scratch for IE 4 in the process doing away with the legacy code.

On the other hand, Netscape tried to add the new features on top of Netscape 3’s code engine, a decision that was to have grave consequences. Another factor was that Microsoft’s DHTML implementation was user friendly and attracted both Web designers and developers alike who could write or design programs without having to refer to textbooks. Netscape’s implementation of DHTML though remained in the realm of elite programmers who had code for lunch, dinner and sex.

The Internet in 1997 was looking up with mass sales of computers and new users wanting to hook up to the Internet. They did not want to know what software to download, what software to use as a browser; all they wanted was the Internet “installed” in the computer, for them to click on. As mentioned earlier, Microsoft was in the business of making OSes and Windows was by far the only OS that most non-geek users were happy with. With Internet Explorer being freely available along with the OS, Netscape suffered a major setback in their browser business.